It's

May 11 and day seven of the ongoing Bhent-Mulaqat (a cordial meeting) Abhiyan of Chhattisgarh chief minister Bhupesh Baghel. As the helicopter carrying Baghel and his entourage of ministers and officials touches down at Mangrelgarh village in Ambikapur district, it triggers a flurry of activity. Villagers rush to welcome the high-profile guests who have come to solicit feedback from them on the government's schemes. On the advice of Amarjeet Bhagat, the local MLA and minister for food and civil supplies, Baghel walks from the helipad to a temple dedicated to the Mangrelgarhi deity, after which he settles down under a makeshift shed with a thatched roof made of Saal leaves. "Has everyone's farm loan been waived?" he asks villagers. "What do you with the handsome amount you earn by selling paddy to the government?" After hearing the mostly positive responses, Baghel switches to some light banter.

If you think the Congress is a laggard in early preparation for polls and rests on its laurels, Baghel is out to disprove that notion. By covering three villages in each of the 90 assembly segments across the state, the incumbent CM is keen on being seen as a hands-on man who susses out local issues in person. Also, most schemes launched by him in the past 42 months in office—be it the loan waiver, paddy procurement at MSP plus prices, schemes for rural landless labourers or the cow dung procurement—have focused on rural areas and the CM wants to judge their impact on the ground. Through the Bhent Mulaqat, Baghel wants to see if his political strategy of securing the hinterland to win 2023 is viable or not.

Besides fine-tuning his popular outreach strategy, Baghel also has to contend with a challenge from within the party—health, rural development and panchayat minister T.S. Singhdeo and his loyalists were conspicuous by their absence, even when the assembly segments being covered under the Bhent Mulaqat programme were in the home turf of the titular maharaja of Surguja.

SCHEMES FOR THE MASSES

What are the schemes Baghel sets so much store by and how will they help him politically in 2023? After coming to power in 2018, the first scheme the Congress government announced was the farm loan waiver, a poll promise. Consequently, farm loans of 1.67 million farmers have been waived, costing the exchequer Rs 6,100 crore. Next up was the paddy procurement scheme—called the Rajiv Gandhi Kisan Nyay Yojana—under which farmers who sell paddy to the government get Rs 2,500 a quintal for their produce, as against the Rs 1,940 announced as MSP (minimum support price) by the Union government. The state offers the highest prices for paddy in the country, and procurement has increased over the years (*see box*). Farmers who grow other crops are also paid Rs 10,000 an acre as input subsidy and an incentive for crop diversification.

Then there is the novel Gaudhan Nyay Yojana or cow dung procurement scheme, whereby cow dung is procured from farmers at Rs 2 per kg, is turned into vermicompost and sold to farmers and government departments at Rs 10 a kg to recover the cost.

Since the inception of the scheme in 2020, a total of 6.92 million quintals of cow dung have been procured at a cost of Rs 138.56 crore. Out of the 310,000 cattle owners in Chhattisgarh, 211,000 have sold dung to the government. A total of 1.03 million quintals of vermicompost, to be used as a nutrient-rich fertiliser, has been sold till date. Arrangements are being made to add cow urine to the scheme.

Though the scheme isn't profitable at present, efforts are being made to give a fillip to the rural economy through the use of unutilised cow dung procured by the government. All-women self-help groups (SHGs) who work at gauthans—rural cattle sheds created under the Gaudhan Nyay Yojana—are making a variety of products from cow dung. From eco-friendly diyas to idols of Ganesha, from candlestands to flower pots, there's a market for such things. Cement and bricks made from cowdung is the next step.

The latest scheme to be directed at rural Chhattisgarh is the Rajiv Gandhi Bhoomiheen Krishi Mazdoor Nyay Yojana, under which registered landless labourers will be eligible to get Rs 7,000 a year. A total of 1 million labourers are expected to benefit.